

The Best Places to Eat West Lake Fish

Lou Wai Lou expensive

If elegant food served in a lakeside setting is what Hangzhou is all about, then Lou Wai Lou – the “Tower Beyond Towers” – is the best restaurant in town. Right on the waterfront, this palatial institution has been in business since the 19th century. It is renowned for its West Lake fish, mooncakes (available during the Mid-Autumn Festival), and *dongpo rou* – fatty cubes of pork belly slow-braised to a buttery softness, attributed to the ubiquitous Su Dongpo. Other specialties include the banquet classic *bai niao chao feng*, a whole chicken braised in stock, and *xiang xia guoba*, shrimp soup poured over sizzling, crispy-fried rice crusts. The decor is a little heavy-handed – sparkling chandeliers, red carpets, gold wallpaper, and dark wooden screens and furniture – though you’d expect nothing less of a restaurant that has its own gilded pavilion moored in the lake. This is accessible only by private boat, and provides the ultimate location for a moonlit evening of gastronomic delight and contemplation.

30 Gu Shan Lu, Hangzhou; open 8:30 AM–8:30 PM daily; www.louwailou.com.cn (needs translation)

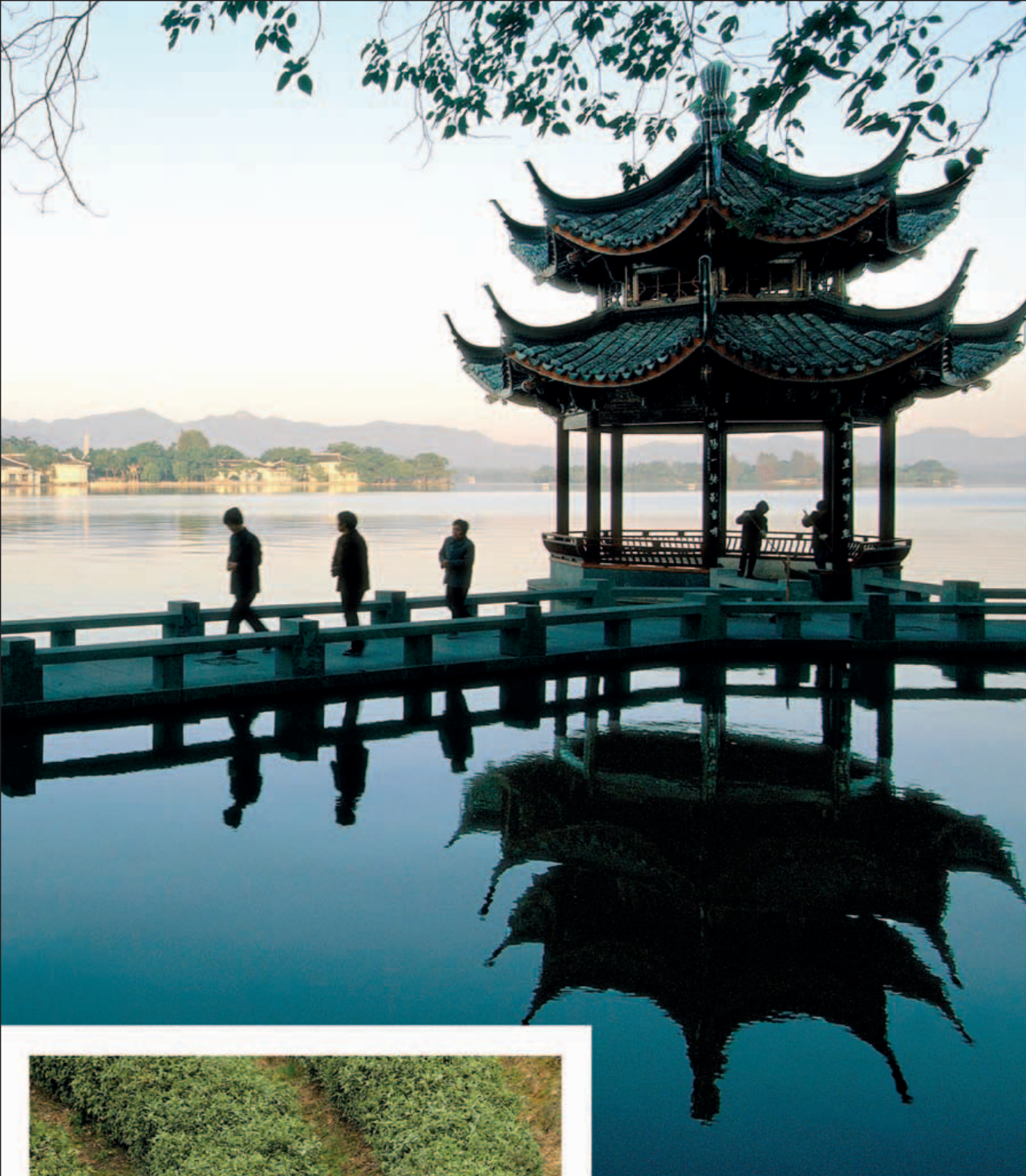
Also in Hangzhou

Tian Wai Tian (+86 571 8796 5450; moderate) is situated in the hills west of Hangzhou, outside the Lingyin Temple. This century-old restaurant features an extensive vegetarian menu alongside local dishes including West Lake fish, Beggar’s Chicken (baked in a clay coating, cracked open at the table), and subtly scented freshwater prawns stir-fried with Longjing tea leaves. It is not as refined as some of the lakeside restaurants, but the food is reliably good.

Also in China

In Shanghai, **Xin Kai Yuan (+86 21 6439 7999; moderate)** is one of a stylish, city-wide chain of restaurants specializing in Hangzhou cuisine, with all the usual favorites, though you should concentrate on their immaculate *dongpo rou* and duck soup, both indulgently rich dishes without a trace of greasiness. After this, the inevitably oversized restaurant lobby, groaning under an ostentatious dressing of marble and auspicious decorations, is excusable in a city that cherishes conspicuous wealth.

In Hong Kong, **Tien Heung Lau (+86 852 2366 2414; moderate)** is a Hangzhou-style restaurant to which elegant furnishings and attentive service are completely alien. But don’t be put off – the food is superb and fresh (many of their classic dishes have to be ordered in advance), including the outstandingly fragrant Beggar’s Chicken, crispy eel, and succulent smoked yellow croaker. If you visit in the fall, try the steamed whole crab or fried shredded crab with noodles.



Above Hangzhou’s signature dish is West Lake fish (*Xi Hu cu yu*), whose simple preparation is typical of Zhejiang cuisine

Left Tea has been harvested from the Longjing (“Dragon Well”) plantations for more than 2,000 years